

HongSeok Kim

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Citizenship: Republic of Korea (F1)

Education

Iowa State University

Ames, USA

Ph.D. in Economics

2021 –

Advisor: Professor Juan Carlos Cordoba.

Hanyang University

Seoul, Republic of Korea

M.A. in Economics and Finance

2021

B.A. in Economics and Finance

2019

Research Interests Macroeconomics, Labor economics, Economics of Aging

Working Paper

[3] **Who Insures the Insurer? Social Security Solvency Risk, Claiming, and Work**

Abstract. Social Security insures households against old-age income risk. But when Social Security itself becomes fiscally risky, households must insure against the insurer. I study how perceived solvency risk changes retirement behavior before any reform is enacted. I build a life-cycle model in which older households jointly choose saving, work, and benefit claiming, allowing them to claim Social Security while continuing to work. Comparing scheduled benefits, a deterministic expected-benefit reduction, and a stochastic solvency-risk environment, I find that recent high-solvency-risk conditions raise employment at ages 62–69 by 4.0 percentage points and increase the claimed-and-working share by 4.3 percentage points. Welfare losses are sizable but mostly reflect lower expected benefits rather than uncertainty itself: the total consumption-equivalent cost is about 4.2 percent of lifetime non-bequest consumption, while the pure-risk component is close to zero on average. Unresolved solvency risk is already a household-level economic shock, inducing older households to self-insure through work and claiming.

[2] **A Vintage Human Capital Model of Skill Recombination**

Abstract. Why has the recent acceleration of technological change coincided with weak aggregate productivity growth? A natural explanation is that the productivity returns to new technologies are dissipated when workers cannot redeploy their accumulated human capital to the task bundles those technologies create. We formalize this intuition by extending the vintage human capital framework of Chari and Hopenhayn (1991) along two dimensions. First, task bundles are destroyed probabilistically rather than only fading with age. Second, workers invest in skill breadth at the start of their careers, anticipating future displacement. A separate parameter captures institutional recombination flexibility, the extent to which a worker’s skills retain value after the original task bundle is destroyed. Whether faster creative destruction raises or lowers cohort welfare depends on a single threshold comparing the frontier productivity gain, weighted by average skill transferability, against the durability of incumbent task bundles. Below the threshold, accelerated destruction reduces welfare even after accounting for endogenous breadth investment; above it, destruction is welfare-improving.

[1] **Ambiguity Aversion and Fertility Decisions**

Abstract. This paper investigates how ambiguity aversion affects fertility decisions, considering the uncertainty surrounding the benefits of parenthood. We extend the Becker and Barro (1988) fertility model by incorporating ambiguity aversion to capture parents’ decision-making process accurately. We assume that individuals care about their own and children’s well-being (dynastic altruism) and face ambiguity about their children’s future abilities (ambiguity aversion). Using a multiple priors utility framework, we model parents’ preferences as maximizing their minimum expected utility of descendants, focusing on the worst-case scenario for their child’s ability. Our findings suggest that more ambiguity-averse parents tend to have fewer children, as they emphasize the lowest possible outcome. This insight helps explain declining fertility rates and rising childlessness in developed countries, as individuals prioritize predictable outcomes over uncertain returns of parenthood.

Fellowships &
Awards

Graduate Teaching Excellence Award (Top 10%), Iowa State University	2026
Graduate Student Workshop Fellowship, Western Economic Association International	2026
Summer Teaching Assistantship, Iowa State University	2025
Most Engaging Presentation Award, EGSA, Iowa State University	2025
Best Discussant Award, EGSA, Iowa State University	2025
Research Travel Grant (\$750) × 4, Iowa State University	2023–2025
Brain Korea 21 Plus Scholarship, Hanyang University	2020–2021
Academic Scholarship HY-IN Graduate School Scholarship, Hanyang University	2020
Academic Fellowship Korea Student Aid Foundation Fellowship	2019
Graduation Award, Hanyang University	2019

Seminar & Conference

Econometric Society in Dynamic Structural Econometrics, University of Michigan [†]	2026
North American Summer Meeting (NASM), Emory University [†]	2026
Asia Meeting of the Econometric Society, East & Southeast Asia (AMES), Vietnam [†]	2026
101th Western Economic Association International [†]	2026
Workshop on AI and Machine Learning for Economists, Iowa State University	2025
Southern Economic Association, Washington D.C	2025
19th Economics Graduate Student Conference, Washington University in St. Louis	2024
Midwest Macro Meetings, Purdue University	2024
Macro Reading Group, Iowa State University	2024
Midwest Economic Association, Chicago	2023

[†]Scheduled.

Academic Experience

Sole Instructor	Iowa State University
ECON 1020: Principles of Macroeconomics (<i>Eval: 4.36/5.0</i>)	Summer, 2025
Recitation Instructor – Graduate	Iowa State University
ECON 6020: Macroeconomic Analysis (Ph.D. Core, <i>Eval: 5.0/5.0</i>)	2025F
ECON 6030: Advanced Microeconomics - Game Theory (Ph.D. Core, <i>Eval: 4.67/5.0</i>)	2023S
ECON 6040: Advanced Macroeconomics Analysis (Ph.D. Core, <i>Eval: 5.0/5.0</i>)	2024S, 2025S, 2026S
ECON 5710: Intermediate Econometrics (Masters)	2026S
Teaching Assistant/Lab Instructor – Undergraduate	Iowa State University
ECON 1010: Principles of Microeconomics	2021, 2023, 2024
ECON 1020: Principles of Macroeconomics	2022, 2023, 2024, 2025
ECON 3020: Intermediate Macroeconomics (<i>Eval: 5.0/5.0</i>)	2025
ECON 3710: Introduction to Econometrics (<i>Eval: 4.29/5.0</i>)	2021

Academic Service

Discussions	
“Urbanicity and Fertility: Evidence from Refugees to Canada”, – Midwest Economics Association Meetings, Chicago	2024
Guest Lecture	
ECON3270 (Economics of Discrimination) – Quantity-Quality Trade-off of Gary Becker’s Model	2025
Other Service	
Economic Help Room Services for the Undergraduates	2021, 2023